
Seoul

A Brand Identity System for a Koreatown Comfort Food Restaurant

A Branding and Visual Identity Project

Seoul. 😊

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Undergraduate Capstone Project Documentation

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Table of Contents

Project Overview	1
Concept Development	2
Research	4
Production	7
Conclusion	12
Bibliography	13

1. Project Overview

Seoul is a Korean comfort food restaurant in New York City's Koreatown, operating out of a food court setting. It serves approachable, comfort Korean dishes at accessible prices, but without a cohesive visual identity to match its dining experience.

The core design challenge was to take a restaurant with an existing customer base and make it more recognizable beyond foot traffic alone. Seoul already had the bones of a brand. It had a homey smiley face logo, a recognizable name, and playful brand touchpoints. But it lacked the cohesion and digital visibility needed to compete in a city where most diners discover new spots by looking at options online first. The goal was not to replace what already existed but to build around it and give the brand the structure and range it needed to grow.



Figure 1. Seoul's original logo at the start of the project.

The approach began with competitor research and an extensive ideation phase exploring logo directions, color systems, and typography. Working closely with the restaurant owners throughout, the final identity centers on a refined wordmark where the smiley face functions as punctuation. Supporting the primary logo are illustrations of the bungeo-ppang fish and a steaming bowl, which carry the food personality and cultural specificity. The full system extends across packaging, a menu, social media, and physical merch including 3D-modeled magnets and stickers.

One of the more interesting tensions this project navigated was working within a genuine client constraint. The owners had a strong attachment to their existing smiley face, which meant the project had to move the brand forward while staying true to what they valued. That negotiation between designer intent and client preference shaped a lot of the decisions made throughout the semester.



Figure 1. Final confirmed primary logo.

2. Concept Development

The first major question going into this project was how to amplify what Seoul already had rather than start from scratch. The brand had a personality, warm and casual, a little playful, but it was not coming through consistently across any of its touchpoints. The design work needed to make that personality legible and scalable.

Brand Values

Key values and associations that guided the visual direction:

- Warmth and friendliness

- Approachability and affordability

- Comfort food with personality

- Casual, playful visual elements: hearts, smileys, bright tones, expressive type

- A neighborhood-oriented, grab-and-go atmosphere

Logo Exploration

Four main logo directions were explored and developed in Adobe Illustrator, each taking a different approach to how illustration and type could work together. Some directions placed a food or character illustration directly inside the wordmark as a letter replacement, while others kept the type clean and let the illustration sit alongside it as a punctuation mark. Each direction was tested across multiple typefaces and color palettes to see how personality and readability held up at smaller sizes.

After owner feedback and peer review, the smiley-as-punctuation direction was confirmed as the primary logo. The secondary illustrations were moved into supporting roles within the brand system, where they carry cultural and food-specific personality without cluttering the main mark.



Figure 4. Refined logo directions developed in Adobe Illustrator.

Color Palette

The primary palette is bright yellow (#FFE500) and jet black (#111111), carried over directly from the original logo and kept as the anchor colors for the new identity. Yellow connects visually to the smiley mark and gives the brand immediate recognition in a busy food court environment. The color consistency between the old and new logo was intentional, respecting the brand equity the owners had already built.

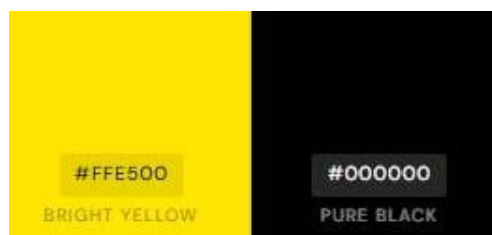


Figure 2. Primary color palette.

Visual Direction

The final visual direction moved away from an earlier hand-drawn, naïve aesthetic toward something cleaner and more polished, while still keeping the playful personality intact. This shows up in the sticker designs, social media posts, and supporting illustrations: bold shapes, strong contrast, and a consistent use of the smiley motif throughout.

Typography

The final typeface for the primary logo wordmark is Fredoka Light, chosen for its rounded, friendly letterforms that match the warmth and approachability of the brand without feeling childish. The Korean text throughout the identity uses Malgun Gothic, a clean and highly legible sans-serif that pairs well with Fredoka's rounded style while remaining neutral and readable at small sizes.

Poster Directions

Several poster concepts were developed to explore how the brand could communicate in a promotional context. These ranged from bold yellow-field graphic compositions to food photography-led designs with the wordmark overlaid in outline type.





Figure 5. Poster direction explorations.

3. Research

Questions Investigated

Several key questions drove the research throughout this project. How do successful small Korean restaurants in NYC build visual identity within the constraints of a food court or grab-and-go setting? What role does social media play in how NYC diners discover local restaurants, and what kind of content actually gets traction? How can a generic symbol like a smiley face be made distinct and ownable for a specific brand? What typography and color systems feel casually warm without looking unprofessional? And how do designers navigate creative constraints when a client is attached to existing brand elements?

Competitor Analysis

Looking at comparable Koreatown restaurants, a few stood out as useful references. Woorijip relies heavily on regulars and foot traffic and presents a warm, homestyle brand that shows off its location and quality upfront. Han communicates clearly through social media with a family-oriented, comfortable feel similar to Seoul's values. Cho Dan Gol leans heavily on food photography and runs a clean, customer-focused feed.

What this research made clear was that even a small amount of intentional design work makes a small restaurant stand out on social media. Most local accounts relied entirely on unedited food photos with no real graphic design consideration, meaning Seoul could stand out significantly with a consistent visual system.

Logo Research

External logo research examined a range of food and restaurant identities to understand how illustration and typography work together in branding. A few key design principles emerged from this research. Logos that integrated a single recognizable illustration into the letterforms read more distinctly than those with complex or overly detailed artwork. Type weight and roundness played a big role in how warm or formal a mark felt. And logos that used a consistent motif across a whole identity, rather than just at the logo level, created a much stronger sense of brand cohesion. These observations directly shaped the decisions made in the Seoul logo exploration phase.

Visual Design Trend Research

Early in the process, research into the naive or anti-perfection design trend influenced the initial direction toward hand-drawn, imperfect visuals. This matched Seoul's casual personality well. Over time, the direction shifted toward something cleaner, keeping the playfulness but tightening the execution, which felt more consistent with where the brand needed to be for professional application.

Market Context and Target Audience

Seoul operates as a grab-and-go stall inside Food Gallery 32 on 32nd Street in Manhattan's Koreatown. Its audience includes local workers, students, area residents, and tourists looking for satisfying Korean food without the formality of a sit-down restaurant. The brand's value proposition is accessible pricing, quick service, bold flavors, and a friendly atmosphere.

A key finding from the research phase was that Seoul's discoverability depended almost entirely on foot traffic within the food gallery. In a city where most diners use Instagram, TikTok, and Google Maps to find new spots, this was a real competitive gap, especially given that the restaurant had no meaningful social media presence or consistent visual identity online at the start of the project.

Peer Survey

A peer feedback survey was distributed during the early logo development phase to gather outside opinions on the four directions before narrowing down. Fifteen responses were collected. The smiley face was the most immediately readable as an O-replacement at 53.3%, while the bowl was the strongest indicator of a restaurant setting at 66.7%. Most respondents preferred typography combined with illustration over type-only or illustration-only identities. Font preference data pointed toward bold and wide-bold styles for market and food court contexts.

4. Production

Tools Used

Adobe Illustrator was the primary tool for logo development, color palette refinement, packaging mockups, menu design, and poster creation. Procreate was used for hand-drawn sketching and sticker illustration. Blender was used for 3D modeling and rendering of the magnet product line. Canva was used for social media post templates and finished content. Figma was used for social media brainstorming and layout planning.

Research and Sketching

The production process started with competitor research and logo ideation. A lot of time went into hand-drawn sketching in Procreate, exploring typography-based directions, illustration replacements for the letter O, and smiley face variations. Social media username ideas and bio copy were also drafted in Figma during this phase.

Logo Development and Owner Meetings

Rough sketches were moved into Adobe Illustrator for refinement. Four logo directions were developed with attention to how illustrations integrated with type, how compositions read at small sizes, and how different fonts affected the personality of each mark. Multiple color palettes were tested across all four directions. Owner meetings were held throughout and the smiley-as-punctuation direction was confirmed as the primary logo following their feedback.

Social Media Launch

The restaurant's official Instagram and TikTok accounts were created. A temporary profile picture using the bungeo-ppang fish logo was applied to both platforms while the final logo was still being refined. The Instagram bio was written to match the brand's voice, and the account was made fully functional with the restaurant website linked.

Packaging Mockups

Quick packaging mockups were built in Adobe Illustrator, placing the confirmed primary logo onto takeout containers, cups, and a kraft paper bag. These were developed as presentation-ready assets for the branding guide.



Figure 6. Packaging mockups, cup and takeout container.

3D Magnet Production

Three 3D magnets were modeled in Blender, one for each secondary logo illustration: the smiley, the bungeo-ppang fish, and the bowl. Each magnet was paired with its own unique backing card designed in Adobe Illustrator. The smiley card used a minimal warm cream background keeping the focus on the yellow mark. The fish card featured the bungeo-ppang illustration surrounded by red bean accents, referencing the pastry's filling. The bowl card used a clean layout with the steaming bowl illustration centered. All three were designed in the style of packaged pins or charms sold in stores. This ended up being a really natural fit for the brand since Seoul already has a playful, collectible personality, and the 3D element added a level of polish and dimension to the system. Material experiments included a glossy shader for the smiley and iridescent shaders for the fish and bowl, with Cycles rendering used throughout.



Figure 7. Individual backing cards for the smiley, fish, and bowl magnets.



Figure 8. 3D-rendered magnet set.

Sticker Design

Stickers went through two rounds. The first round in Procreate produced looser, more hand-drawn versions of the three logo illustrations. At the professor's request, a second round was produced in Procreate and Adobe Illustrator, pulling the stickers closer to the clean feel of the confirmed punctuation logo. Cultural details were added, including a traditional Korean gat hat on one smiley and a bowl and chopsticks on another, to give the sticker set more food and cultural specificity.

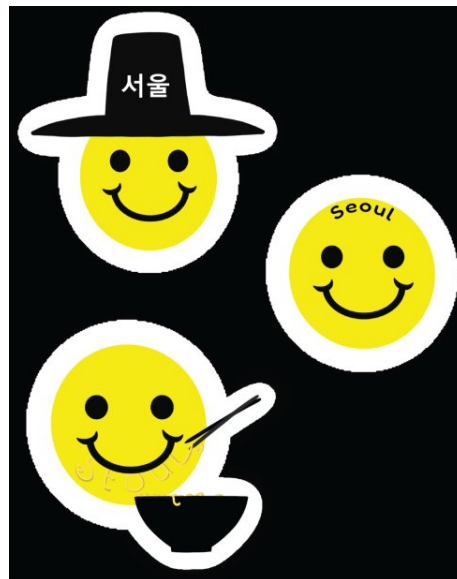


Figure 9. Final sticker sheet.

Menu Design

A print menu mockup was built in Adobe Illustrator using a simplified two-column, three-category layout. The goal was to establish hierarchy, brand feel, and legibility rather than to produce a final print-ready document. The menu header uses the confirmed logo on a black background with the tagline Meat - Rice - Noodle - Koreatown NYC, and the footer echoes the yellow brand color with the secondary wordmark and address.

A full digital menu was also built as a web-based HTML document covering the restaurant's complete menu of 44 items. It uses the same visual language as the print menu: black header with the yellow wordmark, yellow circle item number identifiers, bilingual Korean and English item names, and a yellow footer with the address. This version was built using AI-assisted code rather than a design tool, producing a scrollable HTML page that could be hosted online or shared directly.

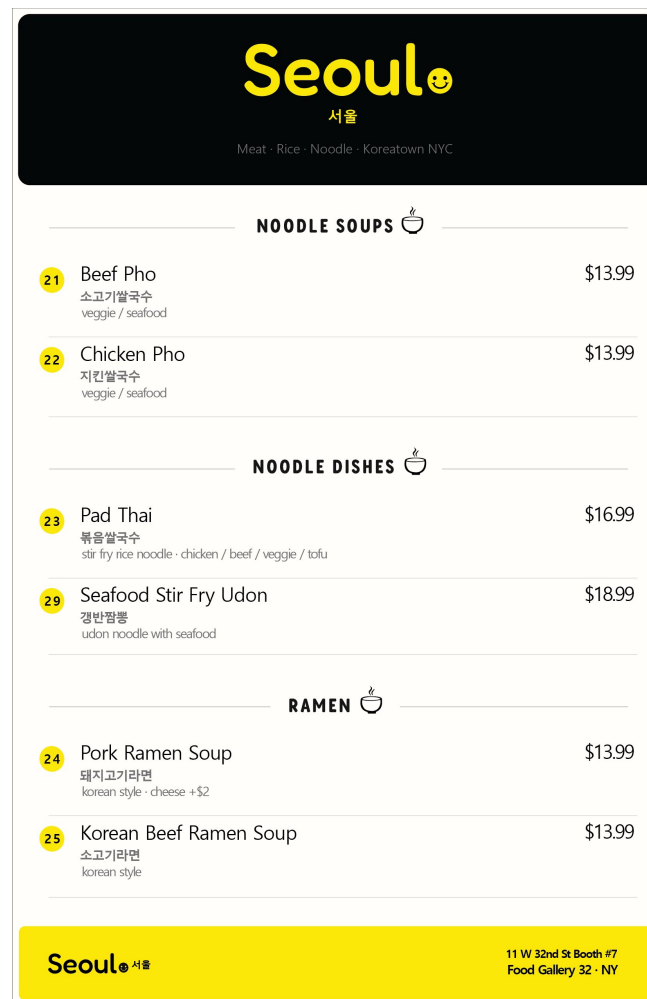


Figure 10a. Print menu mockup.

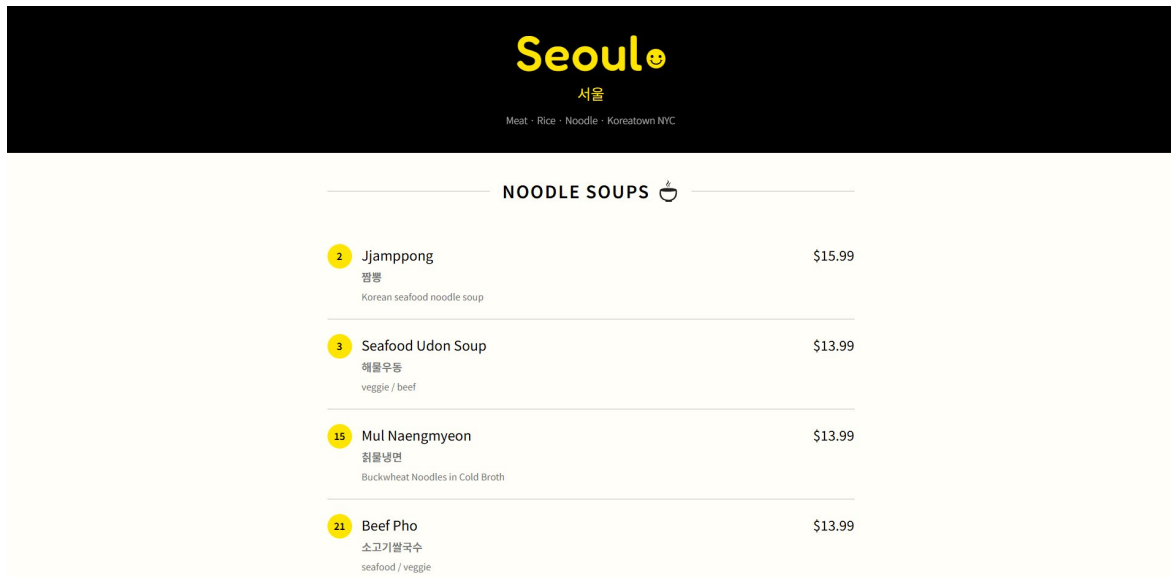


Figure 10b. Digital menu website screenshot.

Social Media Content

An on-site visit to the restaurant was made to photograph food for social media use. Two finished posts were produced in Canva. The first is a multi-slide carousel where someone swipes through six photos taken during the visit: a wide shot of the food spread labeled as the best Korean comfort food in Koreatown NYC, the full stall and menu board with a note about the location, a close-up of the existing restaurant menu, a held combo bowl shot with branded smiley sticker overlays, a flat-lay of all the dishes ordered with labeled callouts, and a branded location and order announcement slide. The second post is a standalone food spotlight featuring the Black Bean Pork and Seafood Noodle Combo with the Seoul wordmark overlaid. Both posts apply the brand's visual language consistently, with the confirmed wordmark, yellow and black palette, and smiley face motif throughout.

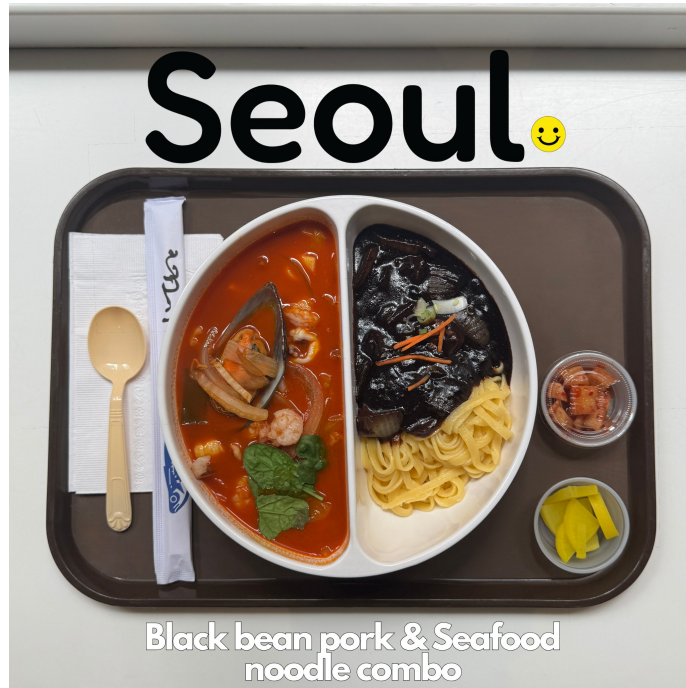


Figure 11. Food spotlight post featuring the Black Bean Pork and Seafood Noodle Combo.

5. Conclusion

Over the course of the semester, this project went from a restaurant with a friendly personality but no real visual system to something that feels like a complete brand. The final deliverables include the confirmed smiley-as-punctuation primary logo, secondary illustrations for the fish and bowl, a defined color palette, a typography system, packaging mockups, a print menu layout, a full digital menu, 3D-modeled magnets, stickers, five poster directions, and a library of branded social media content.

The biggest challenge throughout was navigating the client relationship. The owners' attachment to the existing smiley face shaped the entire direction of the work. Rather than exploring freely, everything had to work within what they valued while still moving forward. The smiley-as-punctuation solution came directly out of that constraint, and it ended up feeling more considered than a complete redesign would have.

The 3D magnet component was probably the most unexpected highlight of the whole project. It was an idea from early in the semester that got talked out of and then came back in the final weeks. It ended up being the most tangible and distinctive piece of the system and a genuinely good fit for the brand's collectible, personality-driven feel.

A simple branding guide was also put together as a final deliverable, covering the primary logo, secondary logo marks, color palette, and typography. It is intentionally concise, meant to give the restaurant and any future designers a clear reference for how to use the brand consistently. Future work would include expanding it further, refining the Blender magnet renders, and growing the social media content library.

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